a significant discount or something for free of any cost.

Are these scammers largely India-based, or are international actors involved too?

Manish: Local fraudsters may amplify their efforts with technological and AI-based interventions.

There is no perfect data to prove the extent of international involvement, but there are cases, case studies and research indicating that outside actors can also become involved.

Are you seeing deepfakes, such as voice cloning, targeting festive shoppers?

Manish: Voice is becoming a significant challenge in the AI era.

Building websites and hosting them on different platforms was already relatively easy, but with AI, fraudsters can create websites that closely resemble the original websites of large retail players, or create entirely new websites in a very short period.

They are also using voice agents. These voice agents can use the names of major brands, actors, politicians and other prominent personalities to make calls, generate leads and attract consumers' attention.

The objective is to make consumers believe that the call is genuine and then direct them to a website, offer them coupons, ask them to download malicious APKs or Trojans, or collect their personal information.

AI is making it easier for malicious actors to create websites, APKs and voice calls, and to conduct deepfake calls using photographs or video calls.

AI can also enable live video calls with fake identities and make the other person believe that they are interacting with a genuine individual.

Do festive scams hit metros ("India") differently from Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities ("Bharat")?

Manish: Scams are everywhere, whether in India or Bharat.



SCAMMER'S FESTIVE PLAYBOOK

MARKET SCOUTING & HYPE IDENTIFICATION

Scammers follow the money. India's e-commerce market is estimated at about $159 billion in 2026, giving fraudsters an enormous pool of festive-season demand to imitate trusted stores, brands and shopping platforms.





FRAUD SCHEME & TARGET PROFILING

Mobile becomes the obvious hunting ground. McAfee's festive research found that 77% of Indian shoppers make purchases via smartphones, putting fake shopping messages, phishing texts and fraudulent mobile ads directly into the

FAKE OFFER & DEEPFAKE CREATION

AI makes the bait harder to spot. In McAfee's 2025 festive research, 69% of surveyed Indians said they or someone they know had encountered scams involving deepfake content or fake celebrity endorsements during holiday





SCAM DELIVERY & MASS OUTREACH

The barrage happens across channels. McAfee's latest 2026 research finds that Indians encounter an average of 13 scam messages every day across text, email and social media, allowing fake deals and impersonation scams to hide inside an

FINANCIAL EXTRACTION & ADAPTATION

Festive urgency can turn deception into losses. McAfee's 2025 research found that nearly one in three surveyed Indians had fallen victim to a holiday scam, with 37% of those victims reporting that they lost money.

